something in the static

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Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s)

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), other princesses mentioned - Character

Additional Tags:
Catra-centric (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), Character Study, gender expression, gender and lesbianism..., Masc Catra, Catra in a Suit (She-Ra), Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Canon Compliant, For the most part, resident lovergirl catra, that lorde quote where she says teenagers know something we don't/adults forget

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by sapphocyra

Summary

She’s the epitome of control to outsiders. Her hair sleek and completely straight back, and her outfit aligns with her position. The overall air to her is different. Sixteen-year-old Catra would look at her and see nothing but a cog in the machine but she wasn’t smart anyway. Catra is the machine now.

or

A study of Catra's gender presentation through the seasons intertwined with her personal growth

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Shadow Weaver declared Catra a nuisance to her existence and hindrance to Adora's success when she was like, five years old. She gets used to the constant beratement; pretending that the bitter old woman is talking to someone else as she drowns it out or sometimes when it's worse than usual, there's no need to pretend as she's watching it happen outside of her own body.

As Catra gets older Shadow Weaver's contempt only manages to grow.

She's bored one day after their designated training slot; this is becoming a more common occurrence. Catra's fourteen and yearns for something outside of the Fright Zone's mechanical walls. She's not sure exactly what but she wants to see the world and just be…above it all.

But that's not in the near future so she perches on a ledge in the training arena and watches a group of older female cadets absolutely brutalize their simulated enemies. She's about to jump down and leave when a group of male cadets come in (because who wants to watch them?) but weirdly some guy's hands catch her eye. There are bandages wrapped around his palm, knuckles and a little over his wrist. Now, don't get her wrong all of the guys are lame. Like, literally all of them but that looks kinda cool.

If she steals a roll of bandages from a supply closet that's neither here nor there.

Catra mimics the look on her own hands and cuts a few holes in her standard grey leggings. For once she looks at herself in the locker room mirror and she looks *cool* . She needs to go find Adora.

Adora's walking in the corridor, more than likely to go to the barracks. Catra sidles up next to her and puts an arm around her

shoulders. “Hey, Adora.”

“Catra! Why weren’t you at dinner? Kyle got milk up his nose and you missed it.”

“Wasn’t it a brown ration bar day?”

“Yeah.”

“That’s why.”

Adora looks at the hand on her shoulder and frowns. “Did you get hurt? I could’ve wrapped that for you.”

“I’m perfectly fine.”

Adora’s eyebrows furrow. “Catra, you promised that if you got hurt again you wouldn’t hide it from me.”

It’s infuriating sometimes how much Adora cares. It makes her brain go all haywire; Catra knows why she wrapped Adora’s bruised knee that one time and kissed it while only nonverbally acknowledging the girl’s tears. She’s known since she was twelve years old. But is Adora’s insistence because she likes Catra back or because she’s just *like that* . (See? Haywire.)

“I’m not *hiding* anything I just thought it looked cool.”

“Oh.” Adora has that look on her face where she’s still confused but isn’t sure if she should keep asking questions.

Catra pulls her arm away and Adora looks at her shoulder for a moment with an indescribable look on her face. She stands in front of Adora and swipes her hair out of her face before balling up her fists. “Tell me I don’t look like some badass fighter guy that no wants to mess with.” She gestures to the rips in her pants for emphasis.

“I can see it.”

Catra smiles.

"...But as your best friend who can totally kick your butt any day of the week –"

Catra gapes before tackling her. "How *dare* you?" Catra straddles her and pins Adora's wrists above her head.

"You still look the part, Catra!" Adora says in between giggling fits. "You just aren't a *badass fighter guy* to me! You suck at punching and…and you're too nice!"

" *Nice* ? I'll show you nice!" Catra shoves her hand across Adora's face, musses up her ponytail, and pokes and tickles at the girl's stomach until she's wheezing.

"Okay! Okay, I surrender. You aren't someone to be messed with. Like those guys in the Crimson Waste that they tell us about."

Catra sits up but not before lacing her fingers with Adora's. "Thank you."

Adora hums. "I do like the look though. And then I guess Kyle is terrified of you. And you beat Lonnie in that fight a few weeks ago."

"I thought you didn't approve of that or whatever."

"Lonnie's our friend. Octavia deserved it a few months ago though."

"Is Adora no longer a goody two-shoes?"

"I never was! She was being really mean though, seriously."

There's a lull and Adora stares at her, unguarded. Catra does the same and there's that never ending feeling in her chest.

Tell her. Tell her. Tell her.

Everyone's off doing their own thing and getting ready for bed. It'd be the perfect timing.

Except it's not, it never is as Adora snatches her hands back and moves out from under Catra. She's about to complain because *Ow* but she follows Adora's eyeline.

"Adora, get off of the floor and ready for resting hours. Tomorrow will be a long training day. Catra, come with me." Adora nods resolutely at Shadow Weaver's command and sends Catra an apologetic look.

She thinks about literally anything else as Shadow Weaver hurls insults at her, and she's grateful that her access to the Black Garnet is limited.

It's the usual talk about Catra being insolent or whatever, until it's not.

"You look like a degenerate. I will not let your depravity pass onto Adora. Do you under –"

Depravity. Degenerate. It doesn't fly under the radar, it's something new.

"What are you even talking about? We were just messing around."

"You may be able to hide your intentions from Adora but you cannot hide them from me. Pull something like that again and you both will suffer the consequences. Do you understand?"

Catra's seventeen and nothing she does can appease Shadow Weaver and the Horde so she stops trying. She skips training – much to Adora's chagrin – and her outfit stands out from the average soldier. Mismatched belts sliding down her waist, holes in

her leggings, and her hair is her hair: it could never be tamed, nor does she want it to be.

Life is better this way and every day she's an inch closer to ruling the Horde by Adora's side. But there's still something just aching and unsatisfied within her. She wants to see the world, she wants to kiss Adora like there's no tomorrow on their balcony, she looks in the mirror and she likes how she looks but she wants *something* that she can't even begin to put into words.

Adora leaves and everything is pointless until she gets promoted.

Catra sees a few places outside of the Horde; Salineas will forever be awful, her and water just do not mix. She goes to the Kingdom of Snows for a princess ball and she wears a suit paired with black fingerless gloves. She doesn't have to stamp down the skin crawling feeling of – no, being *perceived* as inferior for the night, because she isn't. This is what she wants when she looks in the mirror. There's still no word for it but there's a knowing in her gut.

Things fall apart as they always do in her life and she ends up in the Crimson Waste. But just like how things always fall apart, she finds a way to put the pieces back together.

With surprising help from Scorpia, she takes over a gang and the Wastes in general. God, does she look good with a leather jacket and a whip. She feels like she's on top of the world and… *happy.* It's exhilarating.

Hordak lost sight of her worth but Catra did too for a moment. Something about being a badass fighter guy… (And she doesn't like to reminisce but that was about her, not Adora) it was juvenile the way she put it but she had the right idea. Catra looks at the men in the audience toasting their drinks to her, and cheering her

on, those same leather jackets donned on their backs with attire to match. (There's not too much she could do about her Horde uniform.) She can't help but think she wears it better.

Catra's nineteen and she finally grows up. They're at the height of the war and she *gets it* now. She knows what she was doing wrong all along. Entertaining friends, love, and just anything outside of winning. Being stupidly rebellious with her clothes, skipping training, picking fights and most of them being over *Adora* of all people. (Adora is an entire thing within itself too. She left and Catra rose through the ranks, she finally wasn't disrespected at every turn and people *saw* her, saw what she can accomplish. Yet she spent her entire life up until that point loving a girl who in reality held the key to her prison cell. Naivete at its finest.) The Rebellion is in a precarious position, the Horde is winning and she is quite literally on top of the world. Not even Hordak can touch her now.

She's the epitome of control to outsiders. Her hair sleek and completely straight back, and her outfit aligns with her position. The overall air to her is different. Sixteen year old Catra would look at her and see nothing but a cog in the machine but she wasn't smart anyway. Catra *is* the machine now.

However, she did think she'd have more…fun? Maybe even be happy? She probably just needs to get used to it.

Scorpia leaves. But it's fine because Catra doesn't need her, and never needed her. All that matters is the mission.

She doesn’t recognize herself in the mirror anymore. She tells herself it’s a good thing and ignores the growing emptiness that aches within her. It’ll go away when the Horde’s victory has been secured.

She looks out the window a lot of the time on Horde Prime’s ship, it’s addicting yet unsettling to gaze upon the vastness of space. She remembers being fourteen and beginning to *want* . She wanted to be seen and respected but also above it all…whatever that means. Space is weird because she’s remembering things she hadn’t thought about in a long time but also realizes how much she’s forgotten and can’t recall?

She remembers being under the covers next to Adora during a sleepover and giggling, as well as the warmth she felt then. Despite years of her memory being all twisted and corrupt regarding her relationship with Adora, she remembers Adora giggling with her as well. And there was nothing to gain for her weird hero complex then. Huh.

Obviously, she remembers wanting to win in training simulations as a junior cadet, wanting Shadow Weaver and the Horde to appreciate her. But she feels like she’s forgotten everything else. She remembers loving Adora and then trying her damnedest to hate her. She remembers a portal and every decision she made to fuse herself with the Horde. Everything she did to *win* . (None of that satisfied her but does it even really matter at this point? Horde Prime makes Hordak look like a baby.) But there was something else in the middle of all of that. Something that had her unsettled after she fixed her appearance in the mirror of the living quarters Prime gave her. She weirdly felt more at ease with her hair not styled or put together in any capacity, with her outfit more than a little disheveled, and just generally looking like she got into a really bad fight that had you concerned for the other guy.

But as always, Catra's right about her predicament. None of that matters when she's suddenly of use to Horde Prime.

So, she was wholly wrong about Adora. It was a big revelation at the moment but now it's just eh. Another instance of Shadow Weaver poisoning her brain? It must be Tuesday.

She lies down with Adora that second night on the ship. Adora has that same stupidly soft look on her face that she'd give Catra when they were cadets together. The one that drove her crazy or more specifically *haywire* she thinks is what fourteen-year-old Catra used? Anyway, it drives her crazy now not because she's in pubescent love but because Adora looks at her like she didn't try and burn the entire world down. She doesn't know if she'll ever fully make peace with that but she knows no arguing is going to change Adora's mind.

"I like your hair." Adora reaches out to touch a strand that's in her face, Catra notices the hesitation and leans in. "When'd you cut it?"

"I didn't."

Adora yanks her hand back. "Sorry."

"It's fine. I don't hate how it looks, I just hate that *he* did it. Y'know?"

Adora nods. "Any length is good on you just…don't straighten it again."

Catra bites back a smile. “Can I ask why, Miss, *my hair will remain in a ponytail even on my deathbed* ?”

“When it’s all,” Adora makes wide sweeping gestures with her hands. “It suits you more. It’s more like my Catr—“ Adora clears her throat and Catra thanks every God above that she’s the one with sensitive hearing as her heart’s beating a mile per minute. “It’s more like you.”

“I agree with you, actually.”

Entrapta joins the unofficial breakfast circle the next morning cheerfully. “Catra! I made a replica of your last outfit but without the Horde insignia since you’re with us now!”

“Thanks, Entrapta.”

Glimmer looks at Adora and smirks before turning to her. “Y’know, I think Adora here would’ve loved to see you in her clothes for the rest of our trip.”

Adora shoots a glare at Glimmer. “I don’t know why she’s saying that, Catra. I uh – I love how you look in your own clothes.” Adora shoves a dumpling in her mouth while Glimmer looks satisfied with herself.

Something, something haywire…

Entrapta threw in an old belt with her newly replicated outfit and she smiles to herself. There’s really no reason for her to wear one, it especially losing its purpose as she wears it hanging off of her waist but it never stopped her before.

Catra knows she’s made the right choice when she looks in the ship’s bathroom mirror (which is weirdly bigger than the ones in Horde locker rooms) and recognizes herself again. She’s twenty now; maybe her teenage self knows something that she doesn’t with her love, purposeless belts, and numerous holes in her leggings. Maybe her current self can figure out what she knew once again.

Shadow Weaver comes around because of course she does. Catra is a ‘distraction’ to Adora’s destiny and makes her feel ‘confused.’

She wants so badly to say fuck it and leave everything behind. She’s not going through that again when she was starting to feel okay for once, and she’s definitely not gonna sit back and watch Adora sacrifice her life because she thinks it's inherently worth less than everyone else’s. And she really almost does do just that. But on Prime’s ship in the midst of what felt like endless space. she also remembered her own long, buried want to protect Adora, to take care of her in a meaningful way. So she goes back.

Catra learns a lot of things in her first few weeks in Brightmoon. The fountain in Adora’s – or rather her *and* Adora’s – room isn’t for showering, an aunt is your mom or dad’s sister, and there’s an unfathomable amount of food on Etheria. Most of these things Adora just tells her off of the top of her head, saying that they were the first questions she’d had herself. She’s silently very grateful because her two options when she doesn’t know something are asking what could be seen as very stupid questions and tucking the conversation away in her head to decipher later with a dictionary. And yeah, yeah asking for help is okay or

whatever but she was a *commander* and the most successful Horde strategist of all time. Some of that pride just isn't going away.

She also learns that princesses *love* throwing parties, dances, and balls to celebrate. Hence why she's in Glimmer's room trying on outfits for her and Adora. Normally there wouldn't be any way in hell she'd agree to something like this but Glimmer's just trying to help her. (Adora's just there but in no way is that bad. She thinks that's just what comes with being girlfriends because Adora has the same amount of knowledge on fashion as a horse.) She's *trying* to be a good friend, thank you very much.

However… Glimmer picks out a long, black, silk dress for her to try on and Catra hasn't been this unsettled while looking at herself in the mirror for a while. She steps out of Glimmer's closet anyway, being a good friend and all that.

"You look great! What do you think?" Glimmer says.

"Uh…"

"Oh my gosh!" Adora says out of literally nowhere.

Glimmer's head snaps to her. "What?"

"This reminds me of when we were strategizing on how to take back Dryl and you had that vision of Catra. Like it looks exactly like what you said she was wearing."

"...How were you guys ever considered a formidable enemy. You fantasized about the Horde playing dress-up?"

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "It wasn't dress-up."
"Well, I have the same sentiment that I did then. The dress isn't really you."

"Adora! That's for Catra to decide."

"I agree." She's only needed to dress formally for something once before this but even then no dress appealed to her. "I don't think any dresses are really me. Sorry Sparkles."

"You should've told me! We have plenty of suits too. We'll pick this back up in an hour I promised my dad I'd have lunch with him."

Their next makeover session is much shorter, Catra deciding on a white button-up shirt with black trousers, and a black blazer covered in gold embellishments. She feels the same way she did getting ready for Princess Prom all of those years ago, but toned down cause she's not going to a ball to crash it and make the girl that she's in love with jealous. It's mainly just…she likes how she looks. She *really* likes how she looks.

"Catra, you look…wow."

Catra smirks. Glimmer's left already to do whatever with Arrow Boy, she can rile up and mess with Adora without limits. "I see me in a suit does it for you."

Adora adjusts her collar and hums. "No, you being you does it for me. You looked really uncomfortable in the dress."

"It was awfullll." She nearly whines and lets her forehead fall onto Adora's shoulder.

Adora chuckles. "I know that you're nice and you don't wanna potentially hurt our friend's feelings –"

"I'm the Rebellion's biggest threat, actually."

"...But Glimmer won't be hurt by you saying no to something or not liking something she picked out for you. Especially not during her makeovers. I want you to be completely comfortable here, I

don’t want you to ever feel like you have to be something you’re not for other people’s sake.”

She gets Adora’s point but doesn’t exactly see its complete relation to her wearing a suit versus a dress. She’s been through a lot worse than having to wear something she doesn’t like for one night. Maybe it’s a thing she learns with time or something. “I know, I know, we aren’t in the Horde anymore.”

Adora kisses her forehead and then she’s promptly off to her own makeover session.

Catra joins in toward the end, when Adora has on a dress that’s nearly ankle length, white with gold embossment, and flowy from the waist down.

Adora looks great to put it simply.

Adora twists a loose strand of hair around her index finger. “I just…it doesn’t seem ideal to fight in? Like what if there’s a stray group of clones or something?”
“Adora.” Glimmer looks at Catra, eerily calm. “What do you think, Catra?”

“I think you look beautiful. But that doesn’t matter that much, do *you* like it?”

Adora flushes. “I just –”

“Forget fighting. Think only about whether or not you like how you look in this dress.”

“I do. I feel…pretty, as stupid as that sounds.”

“It’s not stupid and you should wear it.”

Catra holds out a hand to dance and this time Adora smiles. When she takes Adora's hand in hers she kisses it and curtsies, mostly to make her laugh but it's surprisingly fulfilling.

She's been in Brightmoon for a year and they're on a break from returning magic to Etheria's surrounding planets. Bow suggests that she and Adora go on a vacation together, she accepts the offer for the both of them and tells Glimmer not to schedule Adora in anything for a week.

They stay in a cozy cabin near a remote town with lots of empty but thriving land.

"Catra, are you ready? I have everything packed up!" Adora shouts from the first floor.

"Yeah! One sec!" Catra adjusts her shirt in their bedroom mirror. She opted to put a leather jacket (a new one that Scorpia has a matching one of) on over white tank-top, and paired it with loose black trousers. She finds that she likes dressing for occasions that aren't formal or war-effort related.

She knows what she was looking for in the mirror for all of those years. Badass fighter guy was a funny way to put it looking back, but hey she did the best she could with the limited terminology she had. She wanted to present in a more masculine manner, to be the prince to her princess girlfriend. Catra gets what Adora meant now, this is who she is. Of course, she likes these things but it's deeper than that, it's why she avoided dress options when she got ready for Princess Prom, it's why she was miserable with her hair straightened and pulled back, when she wore her second in command uniform for all of that time. It's why the dress was more than unsettling to put on before that party, it's the why for *so many* things.

For the first time ever, she understands in full what she wanted as she perched on a balcony at age fourteen. Being above it all was simply existing as herself. Not for the Horde, not even fully for the Rebellion. She doesn't dress for them, she isn't bending over backwards to prove that she's worthy, she's just Catra. Who loves her girlfriend, her friends, and her big space cat. And all of those people love her back.

She heads downstairs. "I'm ready." She laces her and Adora's fingers together, that unguarded expression – *Love,* she now recognizes – on her face. Catra lifts their hands and kisses her girlfriend's knuckles.

End Notes

i literally came up with this at one am and wrote it all in one day, putting my responsibilities on the backburner (you can probably tell)

feedback is always appreciated 33

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